

THE QILVAYAS SYMPHONY

A Player's Guide to the Empire

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"I gaze upon the night sky admiring the stars strewn across Heaven's field. Each one a testament of power, its light piercing through the void to shine upon us. And now to our dawn light I summon you. Lord, have mercy upon us sinful children of Zhuvedus. Give us your light, Lord...and give me my destiny. I am Qilvayas, Emperor of the Zhuvedians. We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf."

—Prayer of Qilvayas on the eve of his coronation

A NOTE ON THIS DOCUMENT

This is a companion for players, not the DM's working sourcebook. It collects what an educated person in the Empire of Zhuvedus — particularly a final-year student of the Imperial Academy — would generally know: the shape of the world, its history, its politics, its faith, and the figures who hold power in it. It leaves things out on purpose. Some mysteries in this world are mysteries to the characters who live in it, and this guide is written to respect that — you won't find spoilers here, and you shouldn't expect to. Treat it the way your character would treat a good education: a solid foundation, not the whole story.

A note on the rules: this campaign runs on the 2014 edition of the fifth-edition rules: the Player's Handbook, Monster Manual, and Dungeon Master's Guide as they stood before the 2024 revision. If you learned the game from the newer books, most of what you know still applies, but a few things do not — there are no weapon masteries here, backgrounds and ancestries work the older way, and exhaustion, grappling, and a handful of spells follow the earlier text. Bring whichever books you own; the table will sort out the differences, and none of them change the story.

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW

The Qilvayas Symphony is a story of imperial ambition, prophetic omens, and moral complexity, set against the backdrop of a crumbling empire. Drawing on the tensions of real history — particularly emperors who sought to restore a fading glory — this is a world exploring legacy, power, the cost of idealism, and the gap between the dream of unity and the reality of a fractured world.

Player characters are final-year students at the prestigious Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, completing their field exercises and planning their futures as independent adventurers. What happens next is for the table to discover.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

THE HEIGHT OF EMPIRE

At its zenith, the Empire of Zhuvedus spanned nearly an entire continent. United under the Lupine Throne and guided

by the principles of the Lupine Matron, the empire represented civilization, law, and order. The Golden Tablets — sacred legal codes established by the empire's forefathers — formed the foundation of Zhuvedian governance and culture. Trade flourished along imperial roads, justice was administered by trained magistrates, and the imperial legions defended the borders against external threats.

The imperial capital, Aenodira, seat of the Lupine Throne, was the beating heart of this civilization — a center of learning, culture, and power that drew the ambitious and talented from across the realm.

TWO CENTURIES OF DECLINE

The empire's decline was not sudden but gradual — a slow erosion over two hundred years. Internal strife between noble houses weakened central authority. Corruption spread through the bureaucracy as distant provinces found ways to avoid imperial taxation and oversight. Military expeditions to reclaim lost territories or suppress rebellions failed, draining the treasury and damaging the legions' reputation. External powers, sensing weakness, pressed against the borders and even seized imperial territory.

Most devastatingly, the empire fractured. What had been provinces became semi-independent "nations," each ruled by ambitious warlords, merchant councils, or noble houses who once swore fealty to the throne but now pursue their own interests. Some maintain the fiction of imperial loyalty while ignoring imperial law. Others have openly declared independence. Still others war among themselves.

The imperial capital remains, and the Lupine Throne is still occupied, but the reach of imperial authority has shrunk dramatically. The empire exists more in memory and aspiration than in reality — until now.

THE EMPIRE TODAY

The empire today is a shadow of its former self, yet it persists. Aenodira and its surrounding territories remain under direct imperial control, and several regions still recognize the Lupine Throne's authority — some genuinely, others opportunistically.

Border Lords and Regional Powers: Former provincial governors, military commanders, and noble houses now rule territories as de facto independent states. Their relationship with the throne varies — some maintain nominal loyalty while ignoring imperial edicts, others have declared independence outright, and a few actively work against reunification.

Merchant Republics: Wealthy trading cities that broke away to avoid imperial taxation, now governed by councils of merchants and guild masters. They prefer the current disorder, which lets them play different powers against each other for commercial advantage.

Warlord Territories: Regions held by military strongmen who rose to power during the empire's collapse. Some style themselves protectors of order; others are little better than bandits with armies.

Imperial Loyalists: Territories that still genuinely support the throne, out of tradition, religious conviction, or pragmatic belief that a restored empire offers better stability than the current chaos.

The borders are fluid and contested. Alliances shift, minor wars flare and sputter out, and ambitious lords constantly scheme for advantage. Into this volatile situation steps the young Emperor Qilvayas, with his vision of restoration.

THE ATLAS — REALMS AND REGIONS

The Crownlands: The imperial core — Aenodira, its river valley, and the districts within a week's march — under direct rule and the only place imperial law functions at full strength. Capital culture runs on the race-days of the Long Course, where the city's two great factions — the Golds and the Greys, named for the stone of the walls they claim — turn sport into politics and politics into sport.

The Ostmark: The eastern march, held by thin legion garrisons and thick tradition. Loyalist by conviction in the towns and by inertia in the countryside. The march's pride is Marshal Gavric Dane, the young commander who brought a lost wolf-standard home after sixty years lost to history.

The Suthmark: The southern breadbasket, genuinely loyalist and deeply devout — the Matron's faith runs older and plainer here than in the capital: harvest processions, field-shrines, saints' days kept by planting calendars. Governed by the ducal house of Vasq — the young Duke Aldous in law, and his mother the Dowager Duchess Emerenn in fact, Velmareth-born and iron beneath the mourning silk. The south carries two scars it does not discuss with outsiders: the Vintage Night, six years past, and the hill country around Castle Greywell, where servant girls have a way of not coming home.

Principality of Tarnovar: A highland nation in the far west, openly independent for a century and pointedly uninterested in reunification. Tarnovari culture is built on the given word: oaths are sworn on standing stones rather than gods, oath-breaking is the one unforgivable crime, and their oldest ballads mourn a betrayed lord whose story no imperial scholar has ever bothered to trace. Their proverb for treating with the throne: "Never again the wolf's word." Ruled by the aging, canny Voivode Ysavet Morn — whose word is absolute everywhere except the Eastmarch, where her kinsman Ban

Dregan Morn keeps the border with the Brekelands by methods she has never sanctioned and never stopped.

Free City of Velmareth and the Delta Compact: The great merchant republic of the river delta and the league of trading towns in its orbit. Rich, ostentatiously neutral, and quietly committed to the fractured status quo — disorder is margin.

The Brekelands: The broken middle-west: a patchwork of warlord holdings where imperial administration simply stopped. The local trouble is the Granary War between warlords Bettra Skarn and Ilmarch Voss, which has produced refugees and burned villages this season. From the west, Duke Garvin Norr absorbs holding after holding into his Reckoning Book; along the eastern hills runs Ban Dregan's Fence, which no Brekeland company raids past twice.

The See of Orlath: A breakaway patriarchate in the north claiming the purer doctrine of the Matron — founded nearly sixty years ago by Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled. Orlath recognizes neither the Matriarchate's authority nor the Office of Omens' monopoly on the divine will, and refugees of conscience drift there still.

Kingdom of Ardven: The young power of the far north: a dozen quarrelsome kingdoms and clan-lands hammered into one crown over fifteen years by King Karvel. Ardven is expansionist, literate, and increasingly confident — Karvel plants monastery schools the way other kings plant fortresses.

The Skellvard: Sea-lords raiding the imperial coast in growing strength — but raiders is only half the truth. The Skell ship-clans are a displaced people, pushed from their northern harbors by Ardven's expansion, led by Sea-King Aldrec the Landless, who once served the empire and was cheated for it.

The Duchy of Normere: The iron surprise of the west coast: a once-minor duchy forged into the most efficient state in the fractured empire by Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard of Normere. Normere's instruments are famous and feared in equal measure — the Reckoning Book, a census of every hide of land and head of livestock the Duke rules, and the personal oath every landholder swears to Norr himself, bypassing all intermediate lords.

THE LUPINE MATRON AND THE IMPERIAL FAITH

The Lupine Matron is the divine patron of the Zhuvedian Empire, represented as a great wolf — wise, protective, and fierce. According to Zhuvedian theology, the Lupine Matron gave the empire's people their core virtues: loyalty, honor, wisdom, and the strength to endure hardship. The phrase "We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf" references this divine connection and appears throughout imperial prayer and ceremony.

The Matron's worship long predates the empire that now venerates her. Zhuvedian doctrine holds that she has guided many champions and many peoples across a span of time far longer than any dynasty's recorded history. Whether Zhuvedus, the empire's founder, ever attained true divinity himself is a matter of genuine and ongoing theological dispute:

Church Doctrine: The Church of the Lupine Matron teaches that Zhuvedus was a mortal hero, chosen and favored by the Matron but never divine himself — virtuous in his triumphs, flawed in his failures, and mortal in his death. To the Church, only the Matron is properly divine.

The Imperial Cult: A smaller, older priesthood tied to the imperial household teaches otherwise — that Zhuvedus was elevated to divine or semi-divine status upon his death, and that the ruling bloodline carries a literal spark of his apotheosis. This doctrine underwrites the throne's claim to hereditary legitimacy.

The Church has no single supreme authority, and never has: the Matriarchate is collegial by design, so that no one voice holds the whole of the faith. The capital Church is governed by the Matriarchate — Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane as the Voice of the Matron in Aenodira — advised by the Synod of the Grey, a council of senior clergy. Beneath them: the seminaries of the Sanctum, the parish structure reaching into every loyalist district, and the Office of Omens, headed by Prelate Sarvin Odell, which claims sole legal authority to receive, examine, and rule on visions, portents, and claims of divine contact. Independent interpreters are known to exist, operating quietly outside the Office's sanction — tolerated uneasily, never fully accepted, found (if at all) through networks rather than any public sign.

The imperial cult's formal body, the Keepers of the Ascent, is small — perhaps forty priests, led by Hierophant Malzeth Corr, maintaining the dynastic shrine within Highcourt. The Church tolerates their existence, and both institutions understand exactly why.

MAGIC, AS LIVED

Every educated Zhuvedian knows the shape of magic in the empire, even if they cannot cast a cantrip. Folk belief — old, universal, and taken seriously even by people who claim not to — holds that sworn words have weight: an oath is a real thing once spoken, stone holds what air forgets, and there are places where too many broken promises have soured the ground itself. The Church neither confirms nor mocks this. The Church, notably, treats vows as sacraments.

The Sanction: Divine magic flows from the Matron, and the Church licenses its lawful practice — a sanctioned cleric carries a pewter warrant-medal, and an unsanctioned healer in Church lands can expect a visit from the Office of Omens. The See of Orlath issues its own rival sanction, and the awkward, carefully undiscussed fact at the center of the schism is that the Matron's power answers both.

Chartered Thaumaturgy: Arcane magic is a licensed profession. A Chartered Thaumaturge of the House of the Craft holds papers enumerating what they may practice; the Charter is prestige, employability, and legal cover in one document. Village hedge-mages work small magic below the Charter's notice — tolerated exactly as long as nothing goes wrong — and Rivergate sells what Rivergate sells.

The Old Observance: The Matron's worship before there was an empire to license anything: field-shrines, first-fruits, the wolf-watch on winter roads. Druids and rangers keep it. The Church's official position is studied non-comment.

The Sworn and the Kindled: Warlocks — the Sworn — are feared in Church lands, because a pact is an oath made to something that answered, and nobody licensed the

something. Sorcerers — the Kindled — carry power without study, which the chartered call cheating and the Church calls a question. Velmareth, characteristically, calls both a market.

The Night Liturgy: The Matron's iconography is the She-Wolf of the Night Sky — the moon her watching eye, the stars her pack, dawn her gift. The great liturgies are sung at night. The Emperor's coronation prayer, addressed to the stars, is theologically exact.

The Wolf-Shape: Church doctrine holds lycanthropy to be profanation — the Matron's image stolen by a curse — and wolf-trials are a recognized (and recognizably abused) proceeding. Older folk belief holds that sometimes the shape is her mark, and that the difference shows in what the changed one does under the moon. Do not repeat this near clergy.

The Packlaw: Church teaching holds that the Matron leads her pack by wisdom and endurance, not raw strength — and that a pack's survival runs through its mothers as often as its sires. It's why nobody in the empire remarks on a woman holding a duchy, a temple, or an army: settled authority answers to this doctrine as a matter of course. Authority still being fought for tends to skew male instead — a pack doesn't easily hand its trust to what hasn't yet proven it belongs.

Marriage and the Denmother's Choice: A wedding vow is a real, binding oath, sworn before a Church witness or, in Tarnovar, at the standing stones — which means an unrepaired betrayal of it is taken very seriously indeed. Divorce exists, but it's a formal Release, not just a parting of ways. Titles and thrones don't simply pass to the eldest child: a ruling parent names their heir openly, and can change that naming during their own lifetime. It makes succession a live question in more than one court right now.

Common and Old Imperial: Nobody is born speaking Old Imperial anymore — it survives only as the empire's administrative and liturgical language, the tongue of the Golden Tablets, the Church's rites, and Academy instruction, learned rather than inherited. Everyone, everywhere, speaks Common as their native tongue; what separates a magistrate's clerk from a farmhand is schooling, not birthplace. Ardven's cheap, subsidized literacy is a point of national pride there for exactly this reason — it's rarer, and more valuable, in the empire than most Academy students stop to notice.

Wildshape: Willed shape is not cursed shape — the wolf-trial has no claim on a druid's wolf-form, and doctrine says so plainly. Folk opinion goes further: villages that would never touch a stray wolf will touch a druid who's just changed back, for luck. The Office of Omens, naturally, still likes to know who can do it.

Physic and Healing: Divine healing runs through the Church's licensed Sanction — reliable, genuinely magical, and priced accordingly. Ordinary medicine is a guild trade like any other: Academy-trained physicians and surgeons, expensive and mostly urban. Everyone else relies on whatever herbwife, bonesetter, or midwife the village has always relied on — perfectly legal, wildly variable, and the only medicine most of the empire will ever actually see.

The Wolf-Price: Self-defense is a real legal defense — report it to a magistrate within three days and the law is satisfied. The law was never the whole of it, though. Older custom says a dead wolf still leaves a debt, paid in coin or

labor to whoever keeps the local shrine, guilt or no guilt. Pay it promptly and the story that follows you is a good one.

The Chosen: A wolf that stays with you by its own will is read as the Matron's visible favor — expect blessings, nods, and pointed questions. A ranger whose beast-bond is a wolf lives this daily, and is treated accordingly — touched, in the provinces; noted, in the capital. A wolf caged or collared is profanation; no honest market in the empire sells a wolf-cage. Feed wild ones at the treeline if you must, and never call them in.

Death and the Vigil: No Zhuvedian body goes into the ground, the water, or the stone before a full night's Vigil, watched and lit — that part never changes. Everything after does: the capital interns its dead in the Bone Galleries beneath the Old Forum (the public stairs serve the upper galleries; the deep levels closed generations ago), the Suthmark times burial to the harvest calendar, Tarnovar inherits a dead kinsman's oaths more than their body, and Velmareth sends its dead to the reed-sea on lit barges. Every town of any size keeps a Vigil Hall for the watching part.

Relics and Mercy: Serious magic in the empire is mostly holy: the Church's almonies sell sanctioned healing at honest prices, and the great relic-treasures hold wonders with provenance — a saint's femur in a mace-head, a standard that has never fallen. Arcane items are scarce, chartered, and papered. Rivergate's relic-stalls are almost always selling fakes. Almost.

PEOPLES OF THE EMPIRE

The Founder's Blood: The dynasty is Drow — the old blood of the founding, the Matron's first-favored children of her night, and nearly gone: a scattering of ancient houses claiming distant kinship, and the throne itself. A Drow stranger in the empire is a sensation, and will be read as dynastic kin, dynastic claimant, or something nobody has words for.

Humans: The great majority everywhere, in proud regional cultures — Zhuvedians, Ostfolk, Suthfolk, Tarnovari, Brekelanders, Velmarenes, Orlathines, Ardvenners, the Skell, Normerines.

Dwarves: The Stonesworn are a third of Tarnovar and fully Tarnovari; hill-dwarf families work the Suthmark's eastern hills; the capital's masons' guild is theirs.

Elves: Wood elves keep the deep forests — Tarnovar's Old Wood, the Ardven wilds — and the eldest ballads. High-elf blood persists in a handful of faded capital houses, more portraits than people now. Half-elves are the empire's courtier class and Velmareth's natural children.

Half-Orcs: Respected legion veteran stock of the Ostmark marches — families who earned the rolls the hard way.

Halflings: The river-trade people: Coppergate's copyists and landlords, the barge families, Velmareth's middle guilds. Collectively the best-informed civilians in the empire.

Gnomes: The House of the Craft's natural constituency — instrument-makers, ward-wrights, archival engineers.

The Marked: Tieflings — bloodlines said to carry an ancestor's bargain made flesh. Feared in Church lands, filed

by the Office, tolerated in Velmareth and Rivergate at the usual rates.

The Sarkanni: Dragonborn mercenary companies from across the southern sea — superb, expensive, and contract-scrupulous: a Sarkanni company has never broken terms in living memory, which in this empire is remarked upon.

The Wolves: Sacred everywhere. Killing one is terrible luck and worse law. Their behavior is read the way other lands read birds.

THE REGIONS: WHAT A TRAVELER SEES

The Crownlands: The Ostrun's terraced valley — cypress windbreaks, poplar roads, the capital's three walls in river haze. The Garrison keeps the empire's last three griffons; the riders' hall keeps every empty saddle oiled.

The Ostmark: Big-sky plains breaking into wooded hills, watch-forts on the heights (many empty — travelers give the failed ones a wide berth after dark, and are right to). Wolf packs are read for omens; ankhegs plague the grain flats.

The Suthmark: Gold grain, vineyard terraces, chalk downs — and eastward, the grey Greywell hills, where the light arrives late. Harvest effigies are shaped like ankhegs, for good reason. The fey of the old orchards are real, and the Church politely does not discuss them.

Tarnovar: The empire's deep wilderness: montane mist-forest, standing-stone rings on the bald summits, and the Old Wood — the largest unbroken forest in the world, where travelers' time is said to run strange. Owlbeats are a fact of the roads. So is hospitality: guest-right in Tarnovar is sacred, sworn, and absolutely not to be tested.

Velmareth & the Delta: Reed-seas and the lagoon city on its ten thousand pilings — bridges, salt-stained marble, money. Giant crocodiles own the reed-sea; the Compact pays a 'channel-toll' to something in the outer waters and does not describe it in the ledgers.

The Brekelands: Broken hill country — wild hedgerows between burned granges, roads that fork around dead villages. Gnoll packs follow the burnings; the old folk say gnolls are what hunger prays to. Wyverns take cattle and, occasionally, tax-collectors, to no one's great grief.

The See of Orlath: Fell-country pilgrim roads, prayer-cairns at every false summit, the mountain city's carved galleries. Orlath feeds the winter wolves at pilgrim stations — the Matron's northern honor guard, they say — a practice the Sanctum calls heresy and the wolves call dinner.

Kingdom of Ardven: Fjords and pine steepes, longhouse towns turning to slate-roofed monastery burghs — the north mid-transformation. The high ranges are dragon-country: white wings over the fells, and ranger companies whose silence about what else is up there is its own answer.

The Skellvard: Not a land — the cold sea, island anchorages, and the clan-fleets. Beneath the Weeping Strait dwells the Saltmaw, to which the clans pay the salt-tithe; its interventions are weather to them. Skell kings are buried under rivers, in secret.

Normere: Rain-lashed headlands and drained polders behind the Duke's dikes; slate towns of ruthless neatness. The coast drills monthly against merrow and sahuagin, attendance recorded. The Weld is on the maps and off the itineraries; do not ask locals about it twice.

EMPEROR QILVAYAS AND THE LUPINE THRONE

THE YOUNG EMPEROR

Qilvayas is a 110-year-old Drow — young by the standards of his long-lived race, but old enough to rule without a regent. He ascended to the Lupine Throne following the mysterious disappearance of his mother, Empress Nyreeza. Raised within the imperial palace, he received the finest education available in history, law, military strategy, theology, and statecraft, and studied the empire's decline intimately.

His youth gives him energy and idealism, but also makes him somewhat untested. He has never commanded armies in the field, never navigated the brutal realities of imperial politics at the highest level, and never faced the compromises that restoring an empire might demand. His vision is clear, his ambition genuine, and his belief in the righteousness of his cause unshakeable.

THE MAN BEHIND THE CROWN

In person, Qilvayas is precise, courteous, and quietly relentless. He speaks softly and in the cadences of law — clauses, provisos, careful definitions — and he never raises his voice. He works brutal hours and sleeps little even by Drow standards. His court has learned to read three habits: he walks the Long Course alone at dawn twice a week; he answers one petition from a commoner personally each day, chosen at random from the pile (the Daily Draw); and he has never, in three years, entered his mother's study. It is cleaned weekly, by his order. Nothing in it may be moved.

THE VISION OF RESTORATION

Qilvayas's plan for imperial restoration rests on several pillars:

Legal Reform: He seeks to rewrite the Golden Tablets, creating a new comprehensive legal code — the "Zhuvedian Laws" — that will modernize governance, eliminate corruption, and provide a unifying framework for all imperial territories. Their promulgation is anticipated this coming Solacre, some nine months out.

Administrative Revival: He is rebuilding imperial institutions that have atrophied or disappeared. The Imperial Academy is central to this effort.

Diplomatic Reunification: Where possible, Qilvayas prefers to bring fractured territories back into the fold through negotiation, offering stability, legal protection, and the prestige of the empire in exchange for renewed loyalty.

Military Force When Necessary: While he prefers peaceful methods, Qilvayas is prepared to use force against those who threaten imperial stability or refuse reasonable terms.

THE ZHUVEDIAN LAWS

Archjurist Senna Vhal's Law Commission is compiling the Zhuvedian Laws as seven short Books, promulgated together this coming Solacre on the Long Course — the empire's first comprehensive legal code since the Golden Tablets. What follows is what a subject of the empire would actually know.

The Tablets themselves don't survive complete, but a few lines are old enough and famous enough that every Academy student still knows them by heart:

"By the will of the Lupine Matron and the true voice of her chosen son, Zhuvedus, is this Empire raised, and these words set down that all who come after may know the order of things."

"No free soul may be bound as chattel, for the wolf does not cage her cubs, and what can vow cannot be owned."

"Let every vow be kept, for a broken word is a wound upon the pack."

"He who spills wolf-blood without cause shall answer to the pack's keeper, and the price shall be paid in full before the moon turns."

"The Throne descends to whom the sitting wolf names before the pack, living or dying, and the pack shall know no other law of blood."

"Set down in the year of the founding, by those who stood witness to the covenant of the Throne, that the memory of that day never fade."

Persons and bound labor: Zhuvedian law is old and clear on the worst of it: owning a person outright is illegal and doctrinally blasphemous throughout the empire — the same principle that makes a sworn oath binding also makes chattel slavery incoherent, since the law holds that only a will capable of making a vow can be owned by no one but itself. What the law does recognize is more complicated: oath-bound personal service (the foundation of Duke Norr's rule in Normere), ordinary time-limited debt-bondage, and hostage-diplomacy — a full guest's legal standing, not bondage at all, and the basis for the Academy's own admission practices. New under the coming Laws: such an arrangement must be sworn before a recognized witness — a Church witness, a magistrate, or a standing stone in Tarnovar — to be enforceable at all. The empire's real trouble isn't the law; it's that the law hasn't reached every corner of the fractured territories in two hundred years, and the Brekelands are where that gap shows worst.

The Marked, and an open question: Whether the Zhuvedian Laws will extend Velmareth's model of full legal standing to tieflings everywhere is the one clause Archjurist Vhal's Commission hasn't settled — sincerely argued on both sides, and still unresolved as Solacre approaches. It's a live question, not a closed one; what happens next may depend on who makes the case, and to whom, before the Laws are read aloud on the Long Course.

Oaths and witnesses: A sworn word binds because it is witnessed — marriage before a Church witness, Norr's personal oaths sworn before his assembled halls, the standing stones of Tarnovar. Swearing falsely before a recognized witness is perjury, tried wherever the oath itself was sworn, and it follows the liar on their own record rather than being settled with a fine.

Certification — the Sanction and the Charter: Every certified good or license in the empire is two things, never one: a physical mark (a wax stamp, a pewter warrant-medal, a charter seal, a guild-stamp) and a matching entry in the certifying body's register — a parish ledger, a Chartered Scriptorium's roll, a guild's books. Carrying unstamped goods or practicing without a license isn't a crime by itself; it just means a magistrate, Church tribunal, or Charter inspector can demand you produce the register entry, and it's failing to produce one — not the missing stamp — that actually opens a case.

Seals and forgery: Forging an imperial instrument — a seal, a signet, a writ, a chartered license — is its own offense: restitution plus a term of indenture, scaling to exile from the jurisdiction on a second offense. A defunct office must formally surrender its seal to the Imperial Archive before its authority lapses; only after that may the instrument change hands as a curio, which is exactly how a trade like Rivergate's dealers in dead offices' seals stays on the right side of the law.

Rank, in brief: Sergeant, Colonel, and Legate mark increasing scale of command in the legions. Marshal is not a rank at all — it's an acclamation the Throne grants a field commander for extraordinary personal renown, regardless of the size of the force they actually lead.

Justice, town to capital: There's no separate civilian watch in the Crownlands or the loyalist provinces — the local garrison keeps the peace, and in Aenodira, the Palatine Guard does. A magistrate hears complaints and rules without a jury; appeal to Aenodira exists but is notoriously slow. Outside the loyalist provinces, disputes often fall to whoever locally holds informal authority — an elder, a shrine-keeper. In warlord territory, there is no magistrate and no appeal at all.

THE MYSTERY OF EMPRESS NYREEZA

Qilvayas's mother, Empress Nyreeza, disappeared three years ago under circumstances that remain unclear. She was the one who began revitalizing the Imperial Academy and took the first steps toward institutional reform. Her sudden absence created a power vacuum that Qilvayas filled, but it also left questions the capital still asks quietly: Was her disappearance natural, political, or something more sinister? Did she flee, was she taken, or is she dead? Does the Emperor know more than he admits? No answer has ever been confirmed. Her loss landed the harder because of what she had been. For a line as long-lived as the Founder's Blood, the Lupine Throne has been an unlucky seat: within living memory its rulers turned over surprisingly fast — fever, faction, a pair of child-heirs and the regents who ruled for them — and Nyreeza, holding it in her own right until a grown son could follow her, was the steadiest the empire had known in generations. That the throne now rests on Qilvayas alone, with no heir yet named, is a thing the capital discusses only in low voices.

THE COURT

Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin: Gatekeeper of access to the Emperor. A career bureaucrat who has outlasted two regents; served Nyreeza first.

Archjurist Senna Vhal: Head of the Law Commission drafting the Zhuvedian Laws — brilliant, exhausted, and the

person who actually holds the pen on the empire's new foundation.

Legate Bruvasca Thorne: Commander of the Palatine Guard, and by any honest reckoning the finest field commander the throne possesses. Her name was made at the Ashline, where she broke a Skellvard raid with eight hundred men against five times that number. The soldiers love her; the court has never quite decided whether her loyalty is a fact or a fortune it hasn't had to spend. Her husband Bram, a retired quartermaster, manages her correspondence and is widely underestimated.

Mistress Averil Shen: Keeper of the Bureau of Correspondence — small, underfunded, and, by reputation the court prefers not to discuss too loudly, rather more than a postal service.

Hierophant Malzeth Corr: Head of the imperial cult. Present at court for every rite and most councils.

THE POWERS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

The rulers and commanders who define the territories of the Atlas.

SEA-KING ALDREC THE LANDLESS — LORD OF THE SKELLVARD CLANS

Aldrec, in his fifties now, served the empire as a young man, and for twenty years after — Skell oarsmen and shock-fighters were cheap, and at the Weeping Strait, twenty years ago, an imperial admiral spent three thousand of them to save his own squadrons and logged it as victory. Aldrec survived, was denied the coastal command he had been promised, and went home to find the fjords already under pressure from the northern crowns as they then were; Karvel's consolidation of them into Ardven, some five years later, only finished it. He has led the ship-clans ever since as a king without a country, raiding the coast of the empire he would rather serve. His demands have never changed: a coastal march to hold, a title to hold it by, and his people's names entered in the empire's rolls as subjects rather than vermin. He speaks fluent, formal Imperial — better than most courtiers' — which unsettles people who expected a savage. Skell kings are buried under rivers, in secret, so that no enemy may ever stand on a Skell king's grave.

MARSHAL GAVRIC DANE — THE YOUNG WOLF OF THE OSTMARK

Not yet thirty-five and already the most beloved soldier in the empire: the man who led the expedition that recovered the wolf-standard of the Ninth from the Brekelands little more than a year ago, nearly sixty years after the Silvasse Disaster swallowed three legions and every banner they carried. He weeps openly at soldiers' funerals, remembers the names of privates' children, and has never once expressed an ambition beyond his command. The legions call him the Young Wolf. The court hears that name and thinks of succession.

BAN DREGAN MORN — WARDEN OF THE EASTMARCH, LORD OF THE FENCE

Kinsman to Voivode Ysavet Morn, sent to the capital academy as a hostage-student in his youth, returned to Tarnovar with perfect Imperial manners and something broken behind the eyes. For thirty years he has held the Eastmarch and made it the safest road in the fractured west by a method the whole continent knows: the Fence, a mile of stakes along the border hills, and on the stakes, oath-breakers. Merchants bless his name. Peasants cross the border toward him. The Voivode has never sanctioned the Fence and never dismantled it.

DUCHESS EMERENN VASQ, NÉE MELDANE — THE DOWAGER OF THE SUTHMARK

Born to Velmareth's great Meldane banking house, married young into the Suthmark's ducal line, widowed at forty some fifteen years ago, and Dowager Duchess ever since — a style carrying no authority at all. The Suthmark's duke is her elder son; every instrument of rule is his, and she has governed through her sons regardless. The devout south never fully accepted the merchant's daughter, and she never asked it to; she governs through the Garland, her web of ladies-in-waiting, priests' housekeepers, and wine-factors, which knows what the Suthmark is thinking before the Suthmark does. Six years ago, Orlathine congregations were massacred in three Suthmark towns during the harvest festival — the Vintage Night. What she ordered, and what it became, are not agreed upon even now; she has never corrected the record, and the south fears her for it.

SAINT-REGENT OLVEA THE RECONCILED — FOUNDER OF THE SEE OF ORLATH

Sixty years ago she was the young widow-regent of a northern principality whose lord had been murdered under guest-right — and what she did about it is still told in the north in four terrible movements. Then, vengeance complete, she walked into a mountain shrine of the Matron and did not come out for a year. What came out was the woman the north now calls the Reconciled. Her title is more precise than it sounds: the See holds the Lupine Throne vacant and its emperor illegitimate, which leaves a seat someone must keep until it can be lawfully filled — Olvesa is Saint-Regent because she keeps it, regent of the True Rite for an emperor not yet crowned. Founder of the See of Orlath and the nearest thing the fractured world has to a living saint — a title she accepts with visible distaste.

KING KARVEL OF ARDVEN

Grandson of Saint-Regent Olvesa, king of a realm he assembled himself: fifteen years of war, marriage, and administration that turned a dozen northern crowns and clan-lands into Ardden. Karvel is broad, loud, semi-lettered and obsessed with letters — he reads slowly and has founded forty monastery schools; he sleeps four hours and audits his reeves personally. This coming Solacre, if nothing intervenes, his grandmother's church intends to crown him Emperor of the True Rite — a second empire, sanctified by a second church, in direct denial of the Lupine Throne's mandate.

DUKE GARVIN NORR — THE BASTARD OF NORMERE

Baseborn son of the old Duke of Normere, acknowledged but never legitimized, who survived three assassination attempts before the age of twenty, took Normere in fact some twenty years ago, and has spent the two decades since building the most ruthlessly administered state west of Aenodira. Norr's conquest of the Brekelands proceeds warlord by warlord, and it is not pillage — it is absorption: every conquered holding is surveyed into the Reckoning Book, every landholder swears a personal oath to Norr himself, and every obligation is recorded, audited, and enforced to the letter. Where submission is refused — the Harrowing of the Weld, four years ago, ended a district's rebellion by ending, for a generation, the district. He styles his conquest "the restoration of lawful administration," which has the special insolence of being partly true.

TITLES AND FORMS OF ADDRESS

The empire keeps no single order of precedence, and that is not an oversight. Two centuries of fracture left the Throne granting titles it can no longer enforce and recognizing titles it never granted — so a Voivode and a Duke are not two rungs of one ladder but the heads of two different kinds of thing. Five ladders run in parallel, each to its own summit.

The Throne and the Court: Emperor; Lord Chamberlain (who keeps access to the Emperor's person); Archjurist (who holds the pen on the new Laws); Mistress or Master, the style of a commoner heading an imperial bureau; Magistrate, judge and civil administrator in one office. Precedence here is by access rather than rank — which is why the Lord Chamberlain, who commands no soldiers and holds no land, is one of the most powerful people in Aenodira.

The Legions: Legionary, Sergeant, Centurion, Colonel, Legate. Marshal is not a rung on that ladder but an acclamation of the Throne for extraordinary renown, which is why a Marshal may command far less than a Legate and weigh far more in the public mind. Captain is a courtesy title for anyone leading an irregular company.

The Church: Matriarch, the Voice of the Matron in the capital, advised and constrained by the Synod of the Grey; Prelate, who heads an office of jurisdiction such as the Office of Omens; Hierophant, who heads the Keepers of the Ascent — the imperial cult, a parallel body and not Church clergy at all. A Prelate holds his writ from the Synod rather than from the Matriarch, so there is rarely a head to appeal over.

The Academy: Chancellor at the head; Professors, senior faculty who may hold a named charge such as Master of Trials; Instructors, junior faculty; and the Archivist, who keeps the restricted stacks. Professor Emeritus is retained for life, whatever the circumstances of the departure.

Sovereign and border styles: King; Sea-King, king of a people rather than a territory; Voivode, Tarnovar's war-leader raised to sovereign; Ban, a march-warden holding a frontier for a Voivode; Duke and Duchess, the imperial ducal houses; Count and Countess beneath them; Lord for any landholder with retainers and no better title; Harborlord for Velmareth's ruling merchant-bankers; Guildmaster for the head of a chartered trade body; and Saint-Regent, unique to Olvesa.

One distinction is worth carrying to any negotiation. Duke Norr and Voivode Morn are not peers of unequal rank — their titles are different in kind. Norr's is imperial, granted by the Lupine Throne, which makes him on paper the Emperor's own subject. Morn's is foreign and owes Aenodira nothing whatever. A Voivode who defies the Throne is a neighbor; a Duke who does it is a precedent.

Where the ladders cross — and a Prelate, a Legate, and a Duchess share no scale at all — the empire runs on an unwritten rule: precedence at court is by access, in the provinces by force, and in a shrine by rite. What happens when those three disagree has never been set down.

Speaking to	Say
The Emperor	Your Radiance, in form; Majesty, in the shorthand of a court that uses it daily
A King, Voivode, or Sea-King	Your Grace
A Duke, Duchess, or Ban	Your Grace
A Count, Countess, or Lord	My lord; my lady
The Matriarch	Your Voice
A Prelate or Hierophant	Your Reverence
Saint-Regent Olvesa	Mother — the See uses nothing grander, at her insistence
A Legate or Marshal	Legate; Marshal. The legions do not embroider
A Magistrate	Your Honor
Academy faculty	Professor; Instructor

Getting one of these wrong is not a crime and rarely even an insult — the empire is large and its usages vary. Getting one deliberately wrong is a sentence with a knife in it, and every soul in the room will hear it land.

THE IMPERIAL ACADEMY OF THE LUPINE THRONE

PURPOSE AND HISTORY

The Imperial Academy was founded during the empire's golden age to train the administrators, officers, and specialists needed to govern and defend such a vast realm. Empress Nyreeza began its revival in the years before her disappearance; Emperor Qilvayas has continued and expanded the effort, seeing the academy as essential to his restoration plans.

Today, multiple Imperial Academies exist across loyalist territories, but the capital academy in Aenodira remains the most prestigious. Graduation from it opens doors that provincial schools cannot match.

ADMISSION AND STUDENT BODY

The empire maintains a policy of universal education — in theory, any subject can seek admission. In practice, admission operates through a lottery that is less fair than it appears: wealthy families make generous "donations," local

lords ensure favored protégés are selected, and some slots are reserved for hostage-diplomacy arrangements. But enough legitimate lottery winners make it through that the system maintains its legitimacy, and the student body remains genuinely diverse — privilege beside scholarship, hostages beside true believers, ambitious commoners beside nobility.

THE THREE HOUSES

HOUSE OF THE SWORD

Trains officers, strategists, and those serving in martial capacities: tactics, logistics, leadership, fortification, and command. Typical classes: Barbarian, Fighter, Monk (Paladins of a martial bent may also claim this house).

HOUSE OF THE SEAL

Administration, law, theology, and governance — the civilian machinery that keeps an empire functioning: imperial law, doctrine, rhetoric, diplomacy, fiscal policy, and record-keeping. Typical classes: Paladins with a doctrinal calling, and Clerics of a pastoral focus.

HOUSE OF THE CRAFT

The most diverse house, for anyone whose skills serve the empire without fitting neatly into command or administration — engineering, medicine, alchemy, cartography, codes, arcane theory, and trade. Most arcane and divine casters study here, magic being treated as a specialized skill like any other. Typical classes: Artificer, Bard, Cleric, Druid, Ranger, Rogue, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard.

Cross-training between houses is common and often required — the empire needs soldiers who understand law, administrators who respect military realities, and specialists who can work with both.

DORMITORIES AND PROGRAM STRUCTURE

Students live in mixed residential halls by year and cohort rather than by house, deliberately building cross-disciplinary friendships and rivalries alike. The standard program lasts four years, culminating in a fourth-year field exercise — a real-world assignment, often in small mixed-house teams, that proves a student can apply their training outside the academy's walls.

LIFE AFTER THE ACADEMY

All subjects of the empire are expected to serve, though enforcement is uneven in the fractured realm. Graduates take direct imperial commissions, return home to regional service, join guilds and civic organizations, or strike out independently as adventurers, mercenaries, and specialists — often reasoning that protecting imperial citizens and interests counts as service enough.

AENODIRA — THE IMPERIAL CAPITAL

Aenodira sits where the Ostrun bends into a wide horseshoe against its northern approach, grown ring by ring to fill everything the river's curve allows and then some. Three walls circle it, each raised in a different age of the empire and each still wearing the color of the age that built it: the Founder's Wall, innermost and oldest, dark and roughly hewn; the High Wall, pale gold limestone raised at the height of imperial wealth; and the Long Wall, outermost, red brick thrown up fast during the empire's last great expansion — the one that came right before the fracture began.

The capital is inland — river trade through Rivergate, but no ocean harbor; the nearest salt water is Velmareth's delta, ten days downriver. Travelers arrive by road (four days from the Ostmark, two weeks from the Brekelands, three weeks from Tarnovar) or up the river itself, and each road teaches its own lessons about the empire before the walls ever come into view.

THE INNER CITY

Highcourt: The palace district. Holds the Lupine Throne, the ministries, and the townhouses of whatever nobility still maintains a capital residence. The Long Course, its ceremonial avenue, is where the legions parade and new laws are read aloud.

The Sanctum: Climbs the city's second hill toward the golden dome of the Great Temple of the Matron — visible from every ring of the city. Administrative halls, seminaries, and the Office of Omens spread around the Temple proper.

The Old Forum: The oldest surviving corner of the city — foundation-stones, half-buried columns, and a weathered monument to Zhuvedus himself, worn smooth by two thousand years of hands touching it for luck.

THE MIDDLE CITY

Coppergate: Copyists, instrument-makers, retired functionaries, laundry strung between balconies. Comfortable and unglamorous.

Scholar's Row: Home to the Imperial Academy — swept courts, ringing bells, and the smaller tutoring houses and lodging-halls that cluster around any institution full of young people with stipends.

The Exchange: Aenodira's guildhalls, counting-houses, and covered markets, where what remains of the empire's trade actually changes hands. Merchant Republic delegations keep permanent offices here.

The Garrison: Barracks, drill yards, and the administrative offices of the capital's legion elements — a smaller and more ceremonial presence than the empire once kept here.

THE OUTER CITY

The Long Wall was built expecting a population that never arrived. The result is an outer city unevenly occupied — half-finished districts standing empty beside others crammed well past sensible density.

The Archwork: An old imperial aqueduct crosses the outer city on high stone arches, several sections long since bricked up and converted into housing. Working-class and unglamorous.

Farrowgate: The newest and least planned district, populated overwhelmingly by displaced people from the fractured territories. Established Aenodirans use the name without much affection; the people who live there increasingly use it themselves. The district's overcrowding breeds its own chronic complaint, a lung-sickness residents call the Damp — no mystery to it, just too many people in too little space with worse drainage than the rest of the city.

Rivergate: The docks and river trade quarter, where goods — and a fair amount that isn't quite goods — move in and out of the capital. Less regulated than the Exchange, and considerably more interesting to anyone asking questions the empire's official record doesn't want to answer.

COMMERCE: WHERE TO SPEND YOUR STIPEND

All mundane prices pulled from the SRD equipment data (exact book values). Magic availability per the approved economy: Church almonries sell sanctioned mercy openly; arcane material is chartered, scarce, and papered; Rivergate discounts everything including the truth.

Prices below are given in the familiar gp/sp/cp shorthand for ease of reference. In hand, the coin changing at every counter is the Zhuven — Zhuvedus's profile struck on one face, the She-Wolf on the other — though almost nobody calls it that. In Common, it's simply a wolf: "three wolves for the room," "a wolf a day, all found." Smaller coin is a silver strand or a copper mote, restruck by whatever mint last had dies on hand.

THE EXCHANGE, AENODIRA — GENERAL OUTFITTING (BOOK PRICES)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Backpack	2 gp	Rope, hempen (50 ft.)	1 gp
Bedroll	1 gp	Rations (1 day)	5 sp
Lantern, hooded	5 gp	Oil (flask)	1 sp
Torch	1 cp	Tinderbox	5 sp
Crowbar	2 gp	Grappling hook	2 gp
Chain (10 ft.)	5 gp	Waterskin	2 sp
Mirror, steel	5 gp	Caltrops (bag)	1 gp
Healer's Kit	5 gp	Climber's Kit	25 gp

THE GARRISON QUARTERMASTER — ARMS & ARMOR (LICENSE INSPECTED, PRICES BOOK)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Shortsword	10 gp	Longsword	15 gp
Shield	10 gp	Chain Shirt	50 gp

Breastplate	400 gp	Crossbow, light	25 gp
Arrows (20)	1 gp	Spear	1 gp

SCHOLAR'S ROW & THE CHURCH ALMONRY — THE SANCTIONED TRADE

Item	Price	Notes
Potion of Healing (stamped)	50 gp	Church almonry; the stamp is the Sanction — possession of unstamped potions invites questions
Potion of Greater Healing	200 gp	Requires standing with a parish, or a pilgrim's writ
Holy water (flask)	25 gp	Book price; Orlathine-blessed flasks trade at a premium or a discount depending on the buyer's politics
Spell scroll, 1st level	100 gp	Chartered scriptorium; purchaser entered in the register
Spell scroll, 2nd level	300 gp	As above, plus a thaumaturgical reference
Component pouch	25 gp	Book price
Ink (1 oz.) / Paper (sheet)	10 gp / 2 sp	Book prices; Scholar's Row runs on both
Spellbook (blank, bound)	50 gp	Book price
Blessed taper (homebrew, common)	5 gp	Burns 1 hour; its light counts as the light of a shrine for purposes of the Old Observance — mostly bought for funerals and promises

RIVERGATE GRAY MARKET — 'EVERYTHING CERTIFIED'

Item	Price	Notes
Any Exchange-list item	~20%	Provenance flexible; quality genuine (the Inkhands guarantee it — their ledgers are their honor)
Unstamped healing potion	35 gp	Works fine. The discount is the

		legal risk, priced honestly
Unlicensed scrollwork, 1st	60–80 gp	roughly a 1-in-6 chance of a flawed casting — the scribe's risk, priced in; the good scribes cost Exchange prices anyway
'Relic' of a named saint	10–500 gp	Almost always false. Almost. (See Part I: the false-relic trade, and the terrifying occasional exception)
Dead-office seals & instruments	Negotiable	Mosse's shop — see Session Five; prices are sentimental

REGIONAL SIGNATURE VENDORS

Vendor	Where	Specialty & Sample Prices
Ostwatch Outfitters (Yanna's cousin's house)	Dravenna	Road & cold-weather gear at book; caravan intelligence free with purchase; wolf-charms 1 sp ('for luck, and it's bad luck not to')
The Stonewright's Yard	Kamenhold	Dwarven-forged tools +10% (worth it); Oathstone Charms 5 gp (see Part VIII homebrew); dry-stone masonry consulting, priced in favors
The Vintners' Hall	Caldessa	Suthmark vintages 1–50 gp; mourning-silk; and the Garland hears every order placed
The Letter-House	Lettervik	Books 25 gp+, maps of the north 10 gp, copying services; Karvel's subsidy makes literacy cheap — the point is the point
The Tithe-Factor	Saltmark	Ship passage, cargo insurance (Saltmaw exclusions in small print), Skell tally-sticks as negotiable instruments

THE IMPERIAL CALENDAR

Twelve months, beginning at Wolfmoon in deep winter — the Matron's own month — and running the ordinary agricultural year most people actually live by.

Month	Season	Known For
Wolfmoon	Deep winter (year begins)	The Matron's high month; the year turns in her keeping.
Thawtide	Late winter	Roads reopen for the year.
Sowmonth	Early spring	Planting begins in the Suthmark.
Greening	Mid-spring	Long Course racing season opens.
Solacre	Early summer	The court's busiest season.
Haymonth	Midsummer	Academy field exercises traditionally run through here.
Harvestide	Early autumn	The Suthmark's great harvest festival.
Vinmoon	Mid-autumn	Grape harvest; Suthmark wines are dated by Vinmoon year.
Fallowmonth	Late autumn	Fields rest; many estates settle inheritance here.
Greywane	Early winter	Racing season closes; days shorten.
Longdark	Deep winter	The Matron's second high month.
Threshold	Year's end	A short 20-day month — old debts settled before the year turns.

Most of loyalist territory counts Years of the Reckoning from the Founding. A seven-day week — a market day, a rest day, five working days — rounds out the everyday structure.

A BRIEF TIMELINE

~2,000 years ago: The founding of the empire by Zhuvedus, first of the Lupine Throne — still celebrated, and still argued about by scholars.

~200 years ago: The fracture begins; two centuries of provinces peeling away follow.

~60 years ago: The Silvasse Disaster: three legions and their standards lost in the western woods.

~60–45 years ago: In the north: Olvesa's vengeance against her lord's murderers, her year of penance, and the founding of the See of Orlath.

~20 years ago: The Weeping Strait, and Aldrec's betrayal by the throne he served.

~15 years ago: Karvel begins unifying the northern crowns into Ardven.

~12 years ago: Empress Nyreeza begins the academy revival and the first institutional reforms.

6 years ago: The Vintage Night in the Suthmark — still disputed, still unexplained.

4 years ago: The Harrowing of the Weld, in the Brekelands.

3 years ago: Empress Nyreeza disappears without explanation.

~2.5 years ago: Qilvayas's coronation; the restoration begins in earnest.

~1 year ago: Marshal Dane recovers the Ninth's standard from the Brekelands — the empire's Young Wolf, and its first clear good news in a long while.

This Solacre (nine months out): Two anticipated events, watched closely across the fractured empire: the promulgation of the Zhuvedian Laws in Aenodira, and the coronation of King Karvel as Emperor of the True Rite in Orlath.

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"We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf"